MAHARASHTRA

THE DEVIL WEARS KOLHAPURI

A global backlash put Prada on the backfoot, but what of the Maharashtrian craftsmen who craft the signature footwear?

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

PRADA. KOLHAPURI. NEVER THE TWAIN SHALL MATCH? Well, the Italian brand has a knack for turning 'inverse snobbery' into high fashion, but it went an extra dusty mile this time. Late June, Kolhapuri-styled sandals catwalked at the Milan Fashion Week. But Prada, er, forgot to tag its humble, Third World provenance. And priced them at Rs 1.2 lakh—in India, you can score a decent pair for one-hundredth of that. A global backlash about 'cultural appropriation' forced Prada on the back foot. Its belated chagrin also put the spotlight back where it belongs: on the Maharashtrian craftsmen who braid centuries of design heritage into each



BORROWED SOLES Models wear Prada sandals at the Milano Fashion Week Men's, Jun. 22

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RAJASTHAN

MEENA'S CRUSADE

Combative agriculture minister Kirodi Lal Meena has unearthed a major farm inputs scam, leaving many jittery

By **Rohit Parihar**



A HARD LOOK Rajasthan agriculture minister Kirodi Lal Meena inspects a fertiliser factory in Ajmer, May 30

Rajasthan agriculture minister Kirodi Lal Meena is on a mission. Since the unearthing of a massive adulteration scam at a fertiliser factory in Ajmer in May (a week after it was given a clean chit by officials), the minister has been personally leading surprise inspections at factories and retail outlets across the state. What he has found stunned even seasoned bureaucrats and agriculture experts: of the 57 samples tested in his presence, 56 failed. The department has now sent 4,772 fertiliser, 4,301 seed, and 283 pesticide samples for testing. The crackdown has led to 28 FIRs and the sealing of 36 locations. "Some of our officials were failing in their duties," Meena told INDIA TODAY. "Fourteen officials have been suspended so far."

The scale of the scandal is causing much jitters. In Rajasthan itself, annual estimated agriculture inputs of fertilisers, pesticides and seeds add up to Rs 56,000 crore. Meena has also found evidence of large-scale collusion by officials with fertiliser manufacturers.

On June 24, Meena sent a letter to Union agriculture minister